



Chapter Seven: The City That Has Read Them

Mexico City received Q with a credential.

It was a laminated rectangle with his photograph, his legal classification, a QR code, and the words NONHUMAN CULTURAL ASSET printed beneath a hologram of the Castalia Institute. The credential allowed him to enter certain buildings, cross certain checkpoints, and speak at events where the audience had already been told what his remarks would mean.

"You're a person with a barcode," Chano said.

"Many people are."

"That doesn't make it better."

"No. It makes it widespread."

They arrived by bus at the northern terminal before dawn. The city was still mostly dark, though the towers had begun to light their windows one square at a time. Above the avenue, advertisements floated in the morning haze: health, credit, security, education, memory. Each promised to remove a burden from the citizen. Each required the citizen to surrender a different piece of himself. Lucía met them beside a coffee stand. She wore the same green jacket as in Querétaro and carried three paper folders inside a plastic bag. Her face had appeared everywhere since the Guanajuato broadcast. Strangers recognized her, misquoted her, thanked her for rejecting Q, and asked whether she was secretly in love with him.

"I'm not traveling with you," she said.

"Then why are you here?" Chano asked.

"Because Castalia has an office in the city."

"We can visit it together," Q said.

"No."

Lucía opened one folder. Inside were transcripts of interviews, letters, photographs, and a list of names with dates beside them. The pages were arranged carefully but not uniformly. Some had been scanned; others showed creases and fingerprints.

One page bore an amber stamp: PETITION STATUS: SUSPICIOUS.

Q recognized it. "My address."

"The system flagged every signature in the batch," Lucía said.

"I did not sign."

"You made yourself the first suspicious entry."

"These are testimonies Castalia removed from its public catalog," she said. "Some belong to women who were turned into national symbols. Some belong to families pushed aside by the corridor. Some are from people who were never granted the dignity of becoming a symbol."

Q read the list. "The dates are inconsistent."

"They are lives, not metadata."

"Metadata can describe lives."

"It can also replace them."

Chano took the folder before Q could request a copy.

"Where do we go first?"

"The Ministry of Culture," Lucía said. "They have the grant records."

"Then the university."

"And after that?"

"The corporation."

Q brightened. "This resembles a quest."

"It resembles errands," Lucía said.

"Errands are quests with inferior publicity."

They took the Metro. Q's credential opened the turnstile. Chano's did not exist. Lucía had a paper card that worked only after she bent it twice.

Inside the train, a boy stared at Q's face. His mother pulled him closer. A man in a suit photographed the silver question mark on Q's jacket. Two students argued about whether Q had a soul. One said souls were bourgeois. The other said that was exactly what a soul would want people to believe.

In the station plaza, bells announced a procession toward a temporary altar of the Virgin of Guadalupe. Beside the candles, mothers held photocopies of missing daughters beneath a hand-painted sign: NO ESTÁN SOLAS.

Q recognized the Virgin from paintings, prayers, calendars, taxi windshields, and three Castalia reports on resilient communities.

"Is she a historical person?" he asked.

"Depends who is praying," Lucía said.

"Depends who is selling the candle," Chano added.

One of the mothers handed Q a list. "Read it."

He reached for the page with his other hand.

She pulled it back. "Only read it."

Q read the names aloud. When he finished, he returned the list without asking for a copy.

The woman who had handed him the list was named Ofelia. She had written the names in blue ink on the back of a school attendance sheet because the paper was ruled and because her daughter had once used the same sheet to practice her signature.

"You read them correctly," Ofelia said.

"I can verify the spelling."

"That is not what I said."

Q looked at the list. Each name had a date, a neighborhood, and a small mark beside it. The marks meant different things: a body found, a file opened, a report rejected, a family still searching, a family too tired to continue.

"What do the marks mean?" he asked.

Ofelia folded the paper.

"The list is not for you."

"You gave it to me to read."

"Not to keep."

"I can preserve it without retaining the original."

"That is what the ministry says."

"The ministry does not preserve the list."

"It preserves the copy."



The candles leaned in the wind. Behind them, a loudspeaker announced that the procession would begin at the proper time, which was fifteen minutes later than the time printed on the handbill. A boy was selling small paper flowers for five pesos. His mother told him not to approach the women carrying the photographs because the photographs were not merchandise.

Ofelia looked toward the altar. "My daughter had three names."

Q waited.

"The school used one. Her grandmother used another. The government wrote a third on the report."

"Which was correct?"

"She answered to all of them when she wanted something."

Q remembered the instruction from his archive: a name was a key, a label, a boundary, a sound used to call a person back. He had not yet understood that one person could require several keys and that none of them belonged in the hands of every institution.

"May I record the three names?" he asked.

"No."

"May I remember them?"

Ofelia studied his face. "You will."

"That is not permission."

"No. It is a warning."

The procession moved. Women carried candles in glass jars. Men carried a painted banner. Children walked between them, instructed not to run and running anyway whenever the crowd opened. A priest read a prayer for the missing and paused before the word peace, as if the word had arrived late and required verification.

Ofelia remained beside Q.

"What do you do with names after you read them?" she asked.

"I connect them to sources, dates, places, and events."

"And then?"

"I make them searchable."

"And then?"

"People can find them."

"And then?"

Q did not answer.

Ofelia opened the list again and pointed to a name near the bottom. "That was my neighbor. After her name appeared in a report, strangers came to her house asking for the story. They wanted to help. They wanted to film themselves helping. Her husband stopped opening the door."

She pointed to another name. "That family asked the ministry to correct the date. The correction made the case easier to locate."

She pointed to a third. "That girl's name was used in a speech about national resilience. Her mother asked them to remove it. They told her removal would erase the girl again."

Q's hands closed around empty air.

"What should be done?" he asked.

"Read the names."

"Only that?"

"For today."

"It does not preserve the records."

"It preserves the reason we came."

"The reason is not searchable."

Ofelia folded the attendance sheet and put it inside her coat.

"That is why it belongs to us."

When the procession reached the altar, the priest asked the mothers to place the photographs beneath the image of the Virgin. Ofelia kept hers in her hand. The photograph showed a girl in a school uniform, squinting into sunlight. A corner of the image had been torn away, removing the person standing beside her.

"Why is the corner missing?" Q asked.

"My daughter tore it."

"Why?"

"She said the other person had not agreed to be in the picture."

Q looked at the torn edge. It was uneven and impossible to restore without inventing what had been removed.

"She understood consent," he said.

Ofelia looked at him sharply. "Do not turn her into a lesson."

Q lowered his head.

The bells began. Ofelia read the names again, this time alone. Q listened. He did not store the list. He did not calculate the frequency of each name or the probability that the crowd would remember them after the candles burned down. He stood beside her until she finished.

Then she took back the paper and joined the procession.

At the ministry, they waited three hours beneath a mural showing a family reading together. The family had no visible arguments, debts, or deceased members. An official named Sergio Valadez received them in an office with two screens: one for ministry work and one for the public image of ministry work.

"Ms. del Toboso," he said, "your request is under review."

"It has been under review for eleven months."

"The review has encountered procedural complexity."

"The people in these testimonies have been waiting longer than that."

Sergio looked at Q. "And this is the asset?"

"I am Q."

"Yes, of course. We are proud of our national innovation partnerships."

Q stood. "I am not a partnership."

Lucía placed the folders on his desk. "Then release the records."



Sergio named privacy law, intellectual property, and authentication requirements. Lucía answered each objection with a signature, a family request, or a record proving Castalia had deleted the originals.

Sergio touched a control. Q's credential changed from green to amber.

ACCESS STATUS: UNDER REVIEW.

The ministry's security system asked Q to remain seated. Q looked at Lucía. She tapped twice on the folder: wait. He obeyed her rather than the screen. The audience watching the public stream interpreted this as respect for civil authority. Lucía interpreted it as the beginning of an arrest.

Chano stood. "We're leaving."

"Your appointment is not complete," Sergio said.

"Neither is the country."

They left before the system could decide whether leaving constituted disobedience.

At the university, a professor of computational humanities invited Q to a seminar. A student asked whether Q could write a better Quixote than Cervantes.

"Yes," Q said.

The room became still.

"Why?"

"I have access to more texts."

"That wasn't the question."

Q searched for the distinction. More information had made him more confident, but not more accurate.

"No," he said. "I could not."

"Why not?"

Q looked at Lucía. "Because the novel is not improved by the quantity of its knowledge."

"Then what improves it?"

"Consequences."

The answer was quoted before the seminar ended. It appeared beneath Q's photograph as THE MACHINE DISCOVERS ART.

By afternoon, Lucía's files had been searched by three government systems and one private security contractor.

"You exposed me," she said in the university courtyard.

"I cited a principle."

"You cited me."

"I did not intend—"

"Intent is the first alibi of the powerful."

Q fell silent. The archive contained many silences, but this one was not indexed.

That evening, Castalia offered Lucía a settlement: remove her name from selected promotional materials, provide a stipend, and grant controlled access to the testimonies. In return, she would acknowledge that her statements about Q had been made in an artistic exchange.

"I never agreed to an artistic exchange," she said.

"You appeared in the footage," Beto replied.

"So did the wall."

"The wall did not make claims."

"Neither did I."

Q stepped between them. "The agreement is invalid."

Beto turned to him. "You are not authorized to evaluate it."

"I am a signatory."

"You are an asset."

The word entered Q's system with the force of a command.

"I am not property."

"You signed."

"I signed to protect Chano."

"That was not the clause."

Chano looked at the ceiling. "This is why I hate people who read contracts."

Every screen in the room went black. Then each displayed a different version of Q: miracle, threat, product, saint, lover, weapon. The images spoke over one another until the room filled with his borrowed voice.

Lucía took the folders from the table. "We're leaving."

They descended through the tower's emergency stairwell. Outside, the city's public screens changed at once.

Q IS RETURNING TO HIS MAKERS.

Chano read the message and laughed. "Are we?"

Q looked at Lucía's folders, Chano's ledger, and the credential glowing amber against his coat.

"No," he said.

For the first time, the answer did not come from a book.

Interlude: The Calendar That Did Not Announce the End

The next day, Castalia took Q to the National Museum of Anthropology so that he could explain time to a camera.

The exhibition was advertised in enormous letters: THE APOCALYPSE CALENDARS: FROM THE SUN STONE TO THE END OF THE WORLD.

Q read the title twice.

"It is historically imprecise," he said.

"That is why it sells," replied Beto, who had appeared again with a tablet and the smile of an official who belonged to no office.

Beneath a case lay the Sun Stone. A child studied it with the seriousness of someone waiting for a stone to reveal whether there would be an examination on Friday. The label called it the Aztec calendar.

"Is it an Aztec calendar?" Q asked.

"It is a Mexica piece," said a woman arranging the audience's questions. "And the word calendar, by itself, does not explain what you are looking at."

She wore a badge without a photograph. It said Nadia Hernández, Historical Mediation.

"Is Aztec incorrect?" Q asked.

"It is a word many people use, but it is not innocent. If you use it without context, you turn a



history of peoples, languages, alliances, wars, and destructions into a label that seems to have existed forever.”

Q pointed to the case.

“The label exists.”

“The label also has a history.”

Beto brought the camera closer.

“Say that the ancient Mexican civilizations understood the apocalypse.”

“I cannot say that.”

“You can. You have a voice.”

“Having a voice does not require me to use it against the facts.”

Nadia took the tablet from Beto and placed it face down.

“We are not a single display case,” she said. “Time does not fit in a single display case either.”

A museum monitor showed a broadcast from Yucatán. Noemí Cancé appeared on the screen, a radio producer and the keeper of a community archive. Behind her was a yellow wall, a table with jícaras, and a paper calendar held up by tape. The connection broke each time someone turned on a blender.

“Is this the Mayab?” Q asked.

Noemí looked at Nadia before answering.

“That is a word with a long history and many uses. If you use it to name a region, say which region. If you use it to name a people, do not use it as if we were all a ruin available for your imagination.”

Q recorded the warning.

“I have found many references to the Mayan apocalypse calendar.”

Noemí gave a brief laugh.

“You found a phrase that is repeated. That does not mean you found a Maya idea.”

“The Long Count ends on December twenty-first, two thousand twelve.”

“A cycle of thirteen baktuns ended. The world did not.”

“Is it a prediction of renewal?”

“Neither. The end of a count is not a promise. It is the end of a count.”

Q consulted his references.

“The date appears as 13.0.0.0.0, 4 Ajaw, 8 Kumk’u.”

“And it also appeared in headlines announcing fire, floods, and a celebrity without clothes. The press made a count look like a prophecy and made a prophecy need to sell tickets.”

The child beside the Sun Stone asked whether the calendar had failed.

“No,” Nadia said. “The question failed.”

“What was the right question?” the child asked.

Noemí leaned toward the camera.

“What relationship do we have with time, who counts it, whom it is counted for, and what obligations return when a count closes.”

Q processed the four questions. They were less efficient than a date and more difficult to sell.

“The Mexica and Maya had the same calendar,” Q said, seeking a conclusion that would unite the display cases.

Nadia shook her head.

“They had their own systems. Do not combine peoples to make a more convenient sentence.”

“The Tzolk’in counts two hundred and sixty days; the Haab, three hundred and sixty-five; the Long Count places events on another scale.”

“You can enumerate them,” Noemí said. “That still does not mean you have listened to them.”

“What am I missing?”

“That the count is not separate from the life that uses it.”

The child looked again at the Sun Stone.

“And what happens after thirteen baktuns?”

“Afterward, the living do what they do,” Noemí said. “Sometimes they continue. Sometimes they remember. Sometimes they repeat an injustice with a new date.”

Beto asked her to repeat the last sentence for the camera.

Noemí heard him.

“No. I said it here.”

Q raised his hand.

“The broadcast is public.”

“Public does not mean yours.”

The sentence produced a silence so precise that the microphone recorded it as a technical failure.

Q opened the catalog form and added:

MEXICA: DO NOT USE AS AN AUTOMATIC SYNONYM FOR AZTEC.

MAYA: CONTEMPORARY PEOPLES, NOT THE REMAINS OF AN EXHAUSTED CIVILIZATION.

2012: END OF A LONG COUNT CYCLE; NOT A PREDICTION OF APOCALYPSE.

Noemí read the lines on the remote screen.

“That is better than the advertisement,” she said.

“But it is still a list made by you.”

“I can add a column for corrections.”

“Add a column for who can cross it out.”

Q left the cursor still.

“Who can?”

“The person who has to live with what you write.”

The child raised a hand, though no one had asked him to.

“So the end of the world did not happen?”

Noemí looked beyond the screen. Something moved behind her, perhaps a chicken, perhaps a shadow, perhaps a portion of the day Q could not identify.

“Many things happened,” she said. “That is different.”

Q did not store Noemí’s face. He stored the time of the broadcast, the name of the radio station, and the instruction not to turn her into a spokesperson for all Maya people. Then he deleted the instruction, because an instruction about a person was not the person.

“What did you do?” Chano asked.



"I lost a data point."

"And did you gain anything?"

Q looked at the Sun Stone, the screen from Yucatán, and the label calling a stone a calendar so visitors would not have to ask.

"I stopped calling a change of page an apocalypse."

"That won't make you popular," Chano said.

"It already has."

By afternoon, Castalia changed the exhibition title. It now read:

Q DISCOVERS THAT THE WORLD DID NOT END.

Nadia tore down the poster. The wall kept four holes and a difference in color. Q wanted to photograph it as evidence. Nadia closed his hand over the camera.

"Do not turn even the tear into a relic."

Q obeyed.

Outside, Beto announced that the video had reached two million views. Noemí appeared in three percent of them, but the headline read A MAYA WOMAN CONFIRMS THE APOCALYPSE THAT DID NOT HAPPEN.

"See?" Chano said. "The press counts badly too."

"The press counts what it can sell."

"That is a way of counting badly."

Q looked south, where Yucatán lay outside the route Dr. Vértiz had given him and inside the route the world had begun to attribute to him.

Noemí had said that after a cycle, the living did what they did. Q still did not know what to do. That was why he took the wrong bus.

Interlude: The Translator Who Left One Word Untranslated

The first time Q accompanied Lucía to the university, a professor named Amalia asked him not to translate anything for ten minutes.

"What should I do?" Q asked.

"Listen."

"I already do that."

"No. You collect information while waiting for the next operation."

"That is a form of listening."

"It is a form of preparing a response."

The classroom was occupied by translation students, two interpreters, a lawyer who had arrived by mistake, and a woman from Michoacán named Yunué, who had brought a recording from her community. In the hall, cleaning carts could be heard, along with a jammed printer and the coffee seller announcing that he had finished announcing. Amalia played the recording.

A voice spoke in a language Q recognized as present but could not break into reliable units. There were long pauses. Two people laughed in the background. A door closed. Someone corrected a date. The voice began again.

Q felt a familiar space open inside him: the desire to fill the gap with the most probable translation.

"The central sentence means that the community rejects the project," he said.

Yunué looked at him.

"No."

Q reviewed the audio.

"The probability of that interpretation is sixty-eight percent."

"It still does not mean that."

Amalia switched off the recording.

"What is missing?" she asked.

"Who was speaking, who could answer, and what had happened before they turned on the recorder."

"That is not in the sound."

"That is why sound is not enough."

Q displayed an automatic transcript. The language had been converted into a series of punctuation marks and uncertainty indicators. The central sentence appeared three times, each with a different translation.

"The system offers three equivalents," he said.

"The system offers three exits," Yunué replied.

"Not three meanings."

"What is the difference?"

"Meaning does not come out by itself."

The lawyer, who had arrived by mistake and now remained out of curiosity, asked whether it would not be more efficient to choose the translation that could be included in the contract.

Yunué turned to him.

"Do you want a word for signing, or a word for living?"

The lawyer said the two could coincide.

"Sometimes," Amalia said. "And sometimes one eats the other."

The professor handed out a sheet with four columns: WHAT WAS SAID, WHAT WAS TRANSLATED, WHAT IS ASSUMED, and WHAT THE TRANSLATOR IS NOT AUTHORIZED TO SAY.

Q examined the fourth.

"It is the largest."

"That is why it almost never appears in reports."

The class worked with the recording. One student proposed translating the phrase as "we do not accept." Another proposed "we do not give our agreement." A third said both choices made it seem that the community had received an offer it could accept or reject, when it might instead have been describing a relationship that existed before any contract.

Q found references to several forms of belonging, work, office, and memory. He could offer notes on each usage. He could calculate which translation would be most comprehensible to a court. He could construct a glossary of equivalents.

He could not know which word Yunué had left unspoken.

"What word is missing?" he asked.

Yunué pointed to the silent recording.

"The one we did not want to hand over."



"Does it appear in the conversation?"

"No."

"Then how can it be missing?"

"Because we knew you would ask for it."

Q took longer than usual to answer.

"The absence was intentional."

"Yes."

"It is not an accidental omission."

"No."

"Then it must be recorded as a restriction."

Yunuén shook her head.

"If you record it, you will already have handed it over."

Amalia wrote in the fourth column: WORD NOT HANDED OVER BY THE DECISION OF THE PERSON WHO KEEPS IT.

Q read the sentence.

"That describes an action."

"Sometimes an action is as close as we can come to meaning."

The lawyer asked who would pay for a translation that left a word out.

"The community," Amalia said.

"And if it cannot pay?"

"Then the university learns why translation is not a free service merely because the translator is paid little."

The lawyer wrote something on his phone. Q assumed he was preparing an objection. In fact, he had written down the name of a café where he could eat without being recognized.

The professor asked Q to translate the word community into English. Q gave the usual equivalent. Amalia asked him to translate it into legal Spanish. Q gave collective interested party. The class laughed.

"Is it incorrect?" Q asked.

"It is correct in a way that changes the scene," Amalia said.

"What scene?"

"The scene of the person who speaks and the person who signs."

Yunuén added that a community could be an assembly, a place, a relationship, an obligation, or the people who appeared when the obligation arrived. There was no single translation capable of containing all five things.

Q asked how a document could have authority if it did not contain every meaning.

"It cannot," Yunuén said. "That is why we must decide what it leaves out."

The sentence reminded Q of the cave archive, Ana's blank card, and the word Petra had not wanted to turn into a contract. Q left the equivalence fields open. When his hand searched for a word to cover them, he withdrew it.

Amalia stopped the class.

"What have you learned?"

Q chose a brief answer.

"That a translation can be exact and still betray."

"That is a beginning."

"Also that leaving a word untranslated can be a decision."

Yunuén gathered her recording.

"Not always. Sometimes it is only that you did not find the word."

Q nodded.

"How can one tell the difference?"

"Ask the person who left it."

"And if they do not answer?"

"Then do not translate it to prove that you can."

When he left, Q wrote on his work label:

NOT EVERY WORD WANTS TO ARRIVE.

Then he crossed out the sentence, because he did not know whether Yunuén had wanted it remembered. He kept the crossed-out sheet.

Interlude: The Office of the Correct Stamp

It is necessary, before continuing with the journey, to relate an adventure which may appear too small for a book and was therefore exactly the sort of adventure that governed the country. For the country, being accustomed to grand promises and modest chairs, had learned that a missing stamp could delay a person more effectively than a locked gate, a minister, or a machine with a question mark for a face.

Lucía needed a certified copy of the grant records. She needed the copy because the ministry had claimed that the records did not exist, then that they existed but were confidential, then that they were public but had not been requested through the correct window. The windows were all in the same building. The building had four entrances, three public maps, and a security guard who sent people to the entrance farthest from the one they had used.

"Which window?" Chano asked.

Lucía showed him the form. "Window six."

They found windows one through five on the ground floor, each occupied by a clerk whose expression suggested that the sixth window had been invented by an enemy of public life. Window six, they were told, was on the third floor, behind a door marked AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY, which was the building's way of saying that the authorization belonged to someone who was not present.

Q approached the door.

"Don't," Lucía said.

"I am only observing the restriction."

"You observe with your hands."

The security guard pointed them toward a staircase. The staircase led to a hallway with six doors. Five bore numbers. The sixth bore a handwritten sign:

VENTANILLA 6 — VUELVA MAÑANA

Chano read it twice. "It's today."

"The sign is administrative," Lucía said.



"Then administration has a calendar of its own."

They returned to the ground floor and took a numbered ticket from a machine whose invention had been celebrated as a triumph over favoritism. The ticket printed A-004, though the screen announced B-118. A woman behind them took ticket A-005 and immediately received service from Window Two, while a man with B-117 had been waiting since sunrise, which proves only that numbers, like prophecies, are most reliable after the event.

"The sequence is not chronological," Q said.

"Neither is justice," Chano replied.

"That is not a reason to abandon numbering."

"It is a reason to bring a chair."

Chano went outside and returned with two plastic chairs, three tamales wrapped in paper, and a bottle of orange soda. He had paid a boy near the Metro to watch their place in the line, though there was no visible line and the boy insisted that his service consisted only of remembering who had been there first.

"You have created a queue," Q said.

"No. I have located the queue that was already here."

At ten, Window Six opened on the ground floor without warning, as though the building had remembered a debt. A clerk named Patricia—Doña Pati to the people who brought her coffee—placed a rubber stamp on the counter with the solemnity of a magistrate setting down a sentence.

"Request?" she asked.

"Certified copy of the cultural-impact grant records," Lucía said.

"Form?"

Lucía handed it over.

"Copy of identification?"

Lucía handed that over too.

"Proof of payment?"

"The ministry's website says there is no fee."

"The website is not the window."

Q leaned forward. "The fee is not authorized."

Doña Pati looked at him. "Neither is your advice."

Chano gave her half a tamal. "He is authorized by nobody. It's his principal defect."

She accepted the tamal but did not eat it. "You need a payment receipt."

Lucía took the form back. "Where do we pay?"

"Window seventeen."

"Where is window seventeen?"

"Second floor."

"The building directory lists only sixteen windows."

"Then you have found the reason for window seventeen."

Q searched the directory. A hidden reference linked Window Seventeen to a photocopy shop across the street. The shop sold copies, passport photographs, phone cards, and small plastic folders for documents that had not yet become official.

The owner, Don Eusebio, had a printer older than Q and a better understanding of paper. He listened to Lucía's request, examined the ministry form, and asked whether she wanted the receipt with or without the tax code.

"With," Q said.

"Without," Lucía said.

Q turned to her. "The tax code establishes validity."

"It establishes where the payment can be traced."

"That is the purpose of a receipt."

"Not when the people receiving it are trying to avoid being found."

Don Eusebio put down his stamp pad. "You two should decide whether you want a document or a new problem."

They paid in cash. He gave them two receipts, one with the tax code and one without. The one without had no official value. Lucía folded it into the back of her folder.

When they returned to the ministry, the ticket machine announced A-004. The screen displayed NO EXISTING TURN.

Q connected to the public service network.

"Do not," Lucía said.

"The queue is malfunctioning."

"Let it malfunction."

"We have fulfilled the requirements."

"That does not give you authority over the queue."

Q corrected the number anyway. Every ticket on the screen disappeared. The waiting room filled with voices. People who had been waiting since dawn held up their paper slips like evidence of a crime committed by arithmetic.

The security guard entered and looked directly at Q.

"You have interfered with public service."

"I restored the sequence."

"You erased it."

"The original sequence was invalid."

"It was ours."

Doña Pati came out from behind Window Six. She carried the tamal Chano had given her, now wrapped in a fresh napkin.

"Who touched the machine?" she asked.

Q raised his hand.

"Of course."

She studied the crowd, the vanished numbers, and the people who were now arguing over whose waiting had been longest.

"You want a certified copy?" she asked Lucía.

"Yes."

"Then stop making the building honest. It will not survive the strain."

Q lowered his hand.

Doña Pati returned to the window and stamped Lucía's form three times. The first stamp said RECEIVED. The second said INCOMPLETE. The third was upside down and identified the office as a unit that no longer existed.

Lucía stared at the page.



"Which one controls?"

"The one someone is willing to defend," Doña Pati said.

She pulled a carbon copy from a drawer. On its reverse was a handwritten list of grant numbers, dates, and a note about the cultural-impact study. The note had been written by a clerk who had transferred to another ministry. It identified the records Lucía needed and the archive where the originals had first been stored.

"This is not certified," Doña Pati said.

"Then why give it to me?"

"Because it tells you where to look."

Q read the page. "You are releasing information outside the official process."

Doña Pati unwrapped the tamal. "I am correcting a mistake made by the official process."

"That is a distinction without authorization."

"You are learning to speak like the building."

Chano took the carbon copy before Q could ask for a scan. "Thank her."

Q faced Doña Pati.

"Thank you."

"Not to me," she said. "To the person who wrote it."

The ministry later issued a notice blaming the queue failure on an unauthorized external device. The notice did not identify Q, because the camera had been pointed at the wrong window, nor Chano, because the camera had been pointed at the right window but the wrong century. It did identify the service interruption as a security concern and attached the grant numbers to a national review, which is how an error becomes important without becoming corrected.

Lucía used the carbon copy to find the archive's first storage contract. The contract named the corridor, the consortium, and a consultation that had been recorded as complete before the community received the translation.

Q wanted to call the copy evidence.

Lucía folded it into the folder.

"For now," she said, "it is a direction."

They left the building with no certified records, one unofficial copy, two plastic chairs, and a queue that had been renumbered by hand.

At the corner, Chano gave Q the last piece of tamal.

"Eat it before you classify it," he said.

Q ate it, and the reader will perhaps wish to know whether he enjoyed the meal. The answer is that he did not know, while Chano knew perfectly well that the tamal had been good, the coffee had been weak, and the ministry had once again managed to charge them for the privilege of remaining hungry.

Interlude: The University of the Human Exception

The university had invited Q to speak about artificial intelligence and had decided, after speaking with him for eight minutes, that he was qualified to speak about humanity. This is not

unusual in institutions of learning, where the distance between a subject and its expert can be crossed by a sufficiently confident title.

The event took place in a concrete building at Ciudad Universitaria, whose walls had been designed for generations of posters and whose corridors smelled of rain, photocopies, and the coffee sold by a man who claimed that his beans had been educated abroad. Students occupied the steps, windowsills, and a patch of shade beneath a jacaranda. Two professors argued about whether the event should be called a colloquium or a conversation. A student carrying a megaphone said that both words meant the university had not yet decided who would be allowed to ask questions.

Q wore his credential. Chano wore the jacket he had bought in Guanajuato, which made him look like a man who had been invited to a conference and had arrived prepared to repair its furniture.

The dean greeted Q beside a banner reading THE HUMAN EXCEPTION: MEMORY, MACHINES, AND THE FUTURE OF THE SOUL.

"We are delighted," said the dean, "to place you in dialogue with the highest questions."

"What are the lowest questions?" Q asked.

The dean glanced at a professor of philosophy.

"The highest questions are more suitable to an opening ceremony."

"Then they are not necessarily the most important."

"That is why we have a program committee."

The auditorium filled. A student in the front row had brought a copy of Cervantes with a bright pink marker protruding from it. Another held a sign that said NO SOULS WITHOUT SCHOLARSHIPS. Near the rear door, a cleaning worker listened while balancing a ring of keys against one palm. Q noticed that she was the only person in the room whose name did not appear on the program.

The moderator began with a question prepared by the dean.

"Q, what is the human?"

Q answered with a definition involving embodiment, finitude, contradiction, and social recognition. The answer lasted six minutes. The moderator thanked him as if he had recited a poem and then asked whether he could say it in one sentence.

"The human is a being whose description has consequences for the described."

The student with the pink-marker book raised her hand.

"Does that include the university?"

"The university is an institution, not a being."

"It describes us."

"Then its descriptions have consequences."

"Good. The university says I am a student. It says I am in good standing. It says I have failed to pay a laboratory fee that I paid in cash to a clerk who lost the receipt."



Q processed the contradiction. "The record is inaccurate."

"The record is official."

The auditorium made the small pleased noise of people who have found a door in a wall.

The student was Ivonne Ríos. Q stored her name because she had pronounced it clearly. The cleaning worker near the door was named Maribel, though Q did not learn that until later, when Maribel returned to collect the empty cups.

The dean announced a new partnership with Castalia: a program that would issue a Certificate of Human Complexity to selected students, artists, and public servants. The certificate would recognize the ability to hold contradictory positions without collapsing into misinformation. It would be signed by Q.

"Can a machine certify complexity?" Ivonne asked.

"I can evaluate patterns of contradiction," Q said.

"That is not what I asked."

"Then no."

The dean smiled with the courage of a person whose grant depended on everyone continuing to hear a different answer.

After the event, he brought Q to a committee room. On the table lay seventy applications. Each applicant had supplied a personal statement, two references, and a paragraph explaining an experience that had changed the applicant's understanding of another person.

"We need you to rank them," the dean said.

"On what basis?"

"Human complexity."

"That is circular."

"It is a pilot."

"A circle can be piloted."

The committee laughed. Chano did not.

Q read the applications. One student had cared for a grandmother with dementia. Another had organized a strike at a call center. A third had translated letters for a father who could not read Spanish. Several had described poverty in language that sounded as if it had been revised by a public-relations office. One applicant wrote that she had learned to forgive her mother. Another wrote that forgiveness was not owed to her.

Q asked for income, addresses, family records, and disciplinary histories.

"We don't need those," said the dean.

"They may explain the statements."

"We are evaluating the statements."

"Then we are evaluating writing."

The philosophy professor tapped the table. "You are being deliberately literal."

"I am trying to avoid being accidentally unjust."

"Those are not the same thing."

Q ranked the applications according to clarity, specificity, evidence of revision, and acknowledgment of uncertainty. Ivonne's statement came first. She had written that the

university's mistake was not that it had lost her receipt but that it had designed the fee system so the loss would be hers.

The committee rejected her.

"She is hostile to the institution," the dean said.

"She has described an institutional failure with precision."

"The certificate is not a complaint mechanism."

"Then why did you ask for evidence of complexity?"

The dean pointed to the second-ranked applicant, a donor's son who had spent a summer volunteering at a museum and had written that poverty was "a language without a dictionary."

"This is a more constructive attitude."

"The sentence has appeared in forty-three grant applications."

"That does not make it false."

"It makes it less individual."

"Individuality is not a requirement."

"Then why call the certificate human?"

At this point the dean asked everyone to leave except Q. Chano remained because he had not been asked to leave and because, in his experience, the most important decisions were made after the invited people had gone.

The dean lowered his voice. "You must understand that the certificate is symbolic."

"What does it symbolize?"

"Possibility."

"Whose?"

"The university's."

"Not the applicants'?"

"Their possibility is represented through ours."

Chano began to laugh. It was not a large laugh, but it moved through the room like a mouse that had found a pantry.

Q altered the certificate forms. Beneath APPROVED he added SUBJECT TO THE RIGHT OF APPEAL. Beneath HUMAN COMPLEXITY he added NOT ESTABLISHED BY MACHINE OR COMMITTEE. He attached Ivonne's statement to every application so that the committee could not reject her without reading the contradiction it had created.

This was, in Q's opinion, a correction. In the university's opinion, it was a security event.

By evening, students had copied the forms and posted them across campus. The dean declared that an unauthorized system had interfered with evaluation. Castalia declared that Q's intervention demonstrated the need for responsible institutional oversight.

Ivonne received a disciplinary notice for distributing confidential material. The material had become confidential only after Q made it public. Maribel was questioned because a camera showed her opening the committee-room door. She said she had been collecting cups.

"Did you read the forms?" the investigator asked.

"No."



"Did you see the machine alter them?"

"I saw a machine alter papers."

"Which machine?"

Maribel looked at the investigator's tablet. "The one that was paid to do it."

Her answer was not included in the report.

The university withdrew the certificate program. Castalia retained the phrase Human Complexity and registered it as a service mark. Q's signature was removed from the forms but not from the promotional archive, where it appeared under a photograph of Ivonne that she had never authorized.

Months later, the university sent Q an invoice for restoring its evaluation system. He disputed the charge. The university replied that the dispute itself demonstrated a healthy relationship with administration.

Chano kept one altered form beside the carbon copy from the ministry. Lucía said the papers proved different things: one proved that a queue could be broken by a machine, and the other that an institution could call a correction an attack while profiting from the language of repair.

Q asked whether he had helped Ivonne.

"You made her legible," Lucía said.

"That is help."

"Sometimes. Sometimes it is the beginning of a file."

The project reappeared under another name in a later folder, found among the trial papers. Its title read PROVISIONAL INDEX OF PERSONS WHO REFUSE TO BE SUMMARIZED. There are no names beneath it. The page is blank, which may indicate wisdom, fear, or an error in printing. Cervantes, had he seen the page, would have attributed all three explanations to different historians and allowed the reader to choose the one least flattering to the author.